

pale gray to
almost black fur



Northern raccoon

Procyon lotor

Dexterous, intelligent, and adaptable, the northern raccoon is found in practically every North American environment, from swamp to mountains, urban streets to farmland. Once a tropical animal that foraged mainly along riverbanks, it has changed into a pan-continental species. Raccoons are now found in a variety of habitats, including deserts and mountains, where they were previously rare, but they prefer watercourses.

Adapt and thrive

“Flexible” describes this extremely successful omnivore best. Raccoons are optimal survivors, locating food in ponds and streams, in trees, and on the ground in the wild, as well as in gutters, garbage cans, and rooftops in cities. Insects, frogs, rodents, eggs, nuts, and berries make up their diet in the wild. In urban areas, they consume almost anything edible they come across—they even raid birdfeeders and outdoor feeding stations of domestic animals. Raccoons generally make their dens in hollow trees or burrows in the

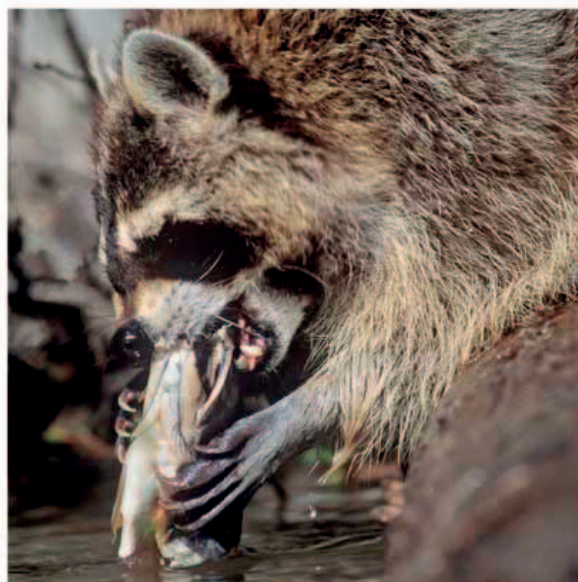
wild, where they hole up during the day and emerge to hunt at dusk. They are just as willing to live in barns, crawl spaces, and attics. Raccoons thrive in towns and cities due to a plentiful supply of food and a lack of natural predators such as coyotes, bobcats, and pumas.

Master manipulator

Raccoons are exceedingly dexterous. The five toes on their forepaws function in the same way as human fingers, allowing them to grasp and manipulate food, as well as turn doorknobs and release latches. They are strong swimmers, relying heavily on their sense of touch—the sensitivity of which may increase underwater—when feeling around for prey such as frogs and shellfish. Even though its hindlegs are longer than its forelegs—giving it a hunched appearance—the raccoon can run at speeds up to 15 mph (24 km/h).

Females give birth to a litter of three or four young, from multiple fathers, called kits, in spring. The kits begin to follow their mother on her nocturnal forays when they are 8–10 weeks old, and remain with her until they are 13–14 months old.

An adult raccoon is **strong enough**
to hold a dog's head underwater



△ FEELING FOR FOOD

With their agile, sensitive fingers, raccoons are adept at finding food underwater. Crayfish is a favorite food source.

◁ TIGHT GRIP

An adult raccoon can catch prey as large as trout. The raccoon keeps a tight grip on its slippery meal with its sharp claws.